

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 131
No. 29



TUESDAY
24TH MARCH, 2026

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Tuesday, 24th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:38 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 6, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS
AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 19th March, 2026, for correction.

Page 1...2—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 1, the item numbered 9, “Ablekuma West” has been spelt as “Ablekuman West”. The letter “n” should be omitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Page 2—Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Assafuah: On the page numbered 2, the item numbered 63, “Essikadu” has been spelt with an ending of “u” instead of an “o”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Table, take note.

Page 3...10—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much for the opportunity. Page numbered 10, item numbered 12(b) and with your kind indulgence, I read:

“The Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and Member for Ellembele, Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah...”

I specifically wish to draw attention to the spelling for the name “kofi” which is a proper noun. If we can delete that and insert the correct form.

On the same page numbered 10, the item numbered 13, titled “MOTION”, on the very last paragraph, which runs on to the next page, the designation accorded, “Mr Richard Acheampong” is incorrect. It is captured as Hon Second—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But on the first one that you raised, the name Armah-Kofi is hyphenated.

Mr Afriyie: Yes, it is hyphenated. However, per our records, referencing it as to how he normally spells it, the “Kofi” is also with a capital “K”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Afriyie: I was on the item numbered 13, the page numbered 10, the very last paragraph—The designation assigned, Mr Richard Acheampong, is incorrect. He is captured here as “Hon Second Deputy Majority Chief Whip”. Indeed, we have to delete the word “Chief”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Table, take note.

Page 11?

Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah:
Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Let me take you back to the page numbered 6, the item numbered 14. My name has been captured as—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, draw the attention of the Table to it. I will not move from the page numbered 13 to and the page numbered 6.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 12, the run on is from the

page numbered 11, the item numbered 2, and I read:

“Now, therefore, this House, in accordance with the said article 268(1) of the Constitution, hereby resolve...”

Maybe for guidance on subject-verb agreement, it should be “... hereby resolves to ratify the said Mining Lease Agreement”. The “s” is missing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note

Page 13—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, not to take you back but, to intervene on behalf of my Friend, Dr Anabah. Sometimes, with some of these things, you may not see it just at the point. So, if we do so, kindly indulge us. We are all trying to help.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Shaib, that is why I said he should draw the attention of the Table to that correction. If I would be at the page numbered 13 and would have to turn back to the page numbered 5, by the time we get to the page numbered 20, and someone takes us back to the page numbered 10, I do not think we can finish correcting the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Practically, what should have even been happening is that, we need to do is to draw the attention of the Table for some of the corrections because they are

not major ones. But here we are in the Parliament of Ghana, correcting *Votes and Proceedings*, including correcting nouns.

Page 14...20—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Assafuah: On the page numbered 19, the item numbered xi, the name "...Afotey-fio", the "fio" has been spelt with "f" but for standardisation purposes if the "f" could be capital.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Page 20...21.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 19th March, 2026, as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Now, let us turn to *Official Report* of Friday, 13th March, 2026. Hon Members, any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Friday, 13th March, 2026.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, permit me to acknowledge the presence of students from Association International School, led by Jamila Yeboah, a teacher. They are from the Ayawaso West Wuogon Constituency and are 11 in number.

[Pupils of Association International School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have the Future Leaders Educational Centre, led by Ebenezer Anim, a headteacher. They are from the Kpone Katamanso Constituency and are 69 in number.

[Pupils of Future Leaders Educational Centre were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Faith Sultan Mehmel Educational Complex, led by Jamal Abdul Nasir, the proprietor. They are from the Tamale North Constituency.

[Pupils of Faith Sultan Mehmel Educational Complex School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have Sam-Doe Academy, led by Raphael Sedoamenda Academy, a teacher. They are from Kpone Katamanso and are 77 in number.

[Pupils of Sam-Doe Academy were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana. May you have a fruitful visit. Kindly resume your seats.

We are done with the item numbered 6. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we would like to take the item numbered 7, Statements. The Minister for Roads and Highways has a Statement that we have agreed on.

12:48 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, before we go on to the item numbered 7, as Leadership had abundantly communicated earlier that the House will adjourn on Friday, I would want to bring you to the notice of the Majority Leader that there are matters that have to be dealt with since we are scheduled to rise on Friday, and these matters I cannot elucidate on. So, I am calling on the Leader of the House that the Minister for Finance be programmed, as was discussed, so that we would have a Committee of the Whole tomorrow in preparation for the House to rise on Friday.

Mr Speaker, it is a matter that has been raging on for a long time, and we on this Side are not happy with it. We have tried to resolve it, but we are not happy with it. Two Motions were filed, one on the mass dismissal and the other on the Gold Board (GOLDBOD). We are not happy with the way these matters have been handled. Of course, we know the processes involved in filing a Motion, and the admissibility of a Motion is in the bosom of the Speaker. Where Leadership has discussed and there is an agreement, and Members have been given prior notice that such a Business will be prosecuted, and then we come and it is something else, it does not speak well of us. We have informed the public and all the stakeholders in these matters, because this matter related to the GOLDBOD is not just about Members of Parliament (MPs), it is a public concern.

We are not happy with how this Motion has been treated. We want this to go on the record. We will go to every legal length permissible to ensure that this Motion is taken. If there is nothing to hide, why are we dilly-dallying? Why are we pretending as if nothing is at stake? The GOLDBOD Motion must be taken by this House. It must be taken.

Mr Speaker, I implore you, direct our Colleagues in the Majority. They must do the needful. They must do the needful. The Motion numbered 42; this Motion has been advertised in the *Order Paper*, not once, not twice, not three times but several times. We are putting the Table Office into disrepute. They will not advertise this Business out of nothing. It was because the Rt Hon Speaker himself admitted the Motion, and the Motion has been advertised in the *Order Paper*. Motion 40, I read;

“That pursuant to Order 127 of the Standing Orders, the Rt Hon Speaker reviews the ruling made on Tuesday, 11th March, 2025 dismissing an application made by Hon Habib Iddrisu in accordance with Order 195(2) seeking the indulgence of the House to determine the form in which the Minister for Finance was to present the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the 2025 Financial Year.”

Mr Speaker, that is one of the Motions. Then Motion 43;

“That this honourable House, pursuant to Article 103 of the 1992

Constitution and Orders 204, 212, 213, 262 and 263 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, establish an Ad hoc Committee to investigate the Gold-for-Reserves Scheme, including its design, implementation, governance, financial performance, environmental and public health implications, and any related matters.”

Mr Speaker, then Motion 39. This has been lingering on for more than a year.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, I read;

“That pursuant to Order 127 of the Standing Orders, the Rt Hon Speaker reviews the ruling of the First Deputy Speaker on 5th March, 2025 sustaining the preliminary objection raised by Hon Majority Leader, Mr Mahama Ayariga, against moving the Private Members’ Motion listed as item number 16 on page 6 of the *Order Paper* for Wednesday, 5th March, 2025 and same captured in the Official Report of the House for the said date.”

Mr Speaker, this has been lingering on for more than a year. What are we doing to this House? What are we doing to ourselves? This is the Parliament of Ghana. The public is interested. Other important stakeholders are interested in this matter; we come and we discuss and flimsy reasons are cited as to why we cannot take the Motion. If they have nothing to hide— Majority Leader, with respect and deference to you, if there is nothing to hide, you should be happy to

come and debate this Motion and let the public know.

Mr Speaker, we are not happy. We on this Side are not happy. We have cooperated and collaborated at all fronts with them. Even when they do not have their numbers, we have collaborated with them. We have always collaborated with them. What is it about this Motion that they keep giving flimsy excuses about? Ghanaians are watching them. The good people of this country are watching them. After giving them these huge numbers, they do not want to debate a simple Motion and they are running away. Majority Leader, are you proud of this? You should not be proud about this. You are a man we respect because of your respect for authority and your respect for procedure. What is it about this Motion that the Majority is afraid of? I am interested in that. What is it about the GOLDBOD Motion that they are afraid of? They dread it. This Motion should not be taken because they are going to be exposed. Yes, that is what it is. He is the chair of the Committee on Economy and Development. He should be happy. He should be happy that this Motion should be taken.

Mr Speaker, the moneys involved are huge. The losses are huge. So, we are simply saying, no, they have the numbers, they should mobilise their numbers to come and vote on it after the debate. Majority Leader, your legacy, in future, we are going to refer to this. That you were the Majority Leader when you fought hard that Motions that concern losses about our country should not be debated and you are not going to be proud about that. Majority Leader, do

something before you die. Do something. No, no, I am not wishing him death, but he must show some Leadership. We on this Side of the House are so disappointed in his Leadership. On this matter, we are so disappointed. He gave his word that the Motion will be taken today and then flimsy excuses are being given.

Mr Speaker, what does he want to say? He should Sit down. Sit down, what does he want to say?

Mr Speaker, so we are saying that unless they allow us to debate and move this Motion— Unless this Motion is moved, Government Business will suffer. Yes, unless this Motion is moved. I am looking into the face of the Majority Leader and telling him boldly that unless this Motion is moved, Government Business will suffer. They should go and bring their so-called 187 otherwise Government Business will suffer. We will not allow you to proceed on that tangent of shielding matters that have to be discussed. The public is interested. Ghanaians are watching them. What is it about the gold reserves that they do not want us to debate? What is this? What is it? They are just frustrating us because they think they have numbers. They should go and marshal their numbers to pass everything that they want to pass from now till Friday. Otherwise, Government Business will suffer, I tell them and I am telling them in plain words. Do not take us for granted. Go and bring your numbers. Otherwise, the Motion must be moved.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the man has just come from cocoa farms — *[Laughter]* — He has been on cocoa farms trying to convince cocoa farmers that in spite of the collapse in the world market price of cocoa, they should be given a rise in their cocoa prices. He has just come back and I think he has missed the point.

Mr Speaker, there is no Motion on GOLDBOD. There is no Motion on GOLDBOD before this House. Let me read the Motion numbered 43;

“That this honourable House, pursuant to Article 103 of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 204, 212, 213, 262 and 263 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, establish an Ad hoc Committee to investigate the Gold-for-Reserves Scheme, including its design, implementation, governance, financial performance, environmental and public health implications, and any related matters.”

12:58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, that is not GOLDBOD. The Gold-for-Reserves is an activity undertaken by the Central Bank, the Bank of Ghana. What has that got to do with GOLDBOD? It has absolutely nothing to do with it. It is about the Central Bank and the Gold-for-Reserve programme that it is embarked upon, which exercise did not begin yesterday.

Indeed, on this Floor, they have argued that this Side of the House should

not take credit for the stability of the cedi because they are also part of the Gold-for-Reserves initiative. Indeed, they tried to argue that credit should be given to Dr Bawumia, that the Gold-for-Reserves is Dr Bawumia's "baby". What has that got to do with the GOLDBOD? So, to rise and seek to scandalise GOLDBOD, and create the impression that GOLDBOD is hiding something, and if we do not move this Motion, we are shielding the GOLDBOD, is totally unfounded because this has nothing to do with the GOLDBOD. This is Gold-for-Reserves, which is a function of the Central Bank.

So, Mr Speaker, let us not be playing to the gallery anytime we have the opportunity in this Chamber. And who is afraid of debating this very simple and innocuous Motion? If there are issues with the Motion, they should straighten out the issues. Nobody is running away from any Motion. What are they going to say that they have not said at a press conference already? There is nothing they are going to say in this Chamber that they have not said at a press conference that Ghanaians have not heard. They say that as a result of the implementation of the Reserve programme, there have been transaction losses, which the International Monetary Fund (IMF) says that an amount of over US\$200 million have been lost.

We can show that several billions of dollars have been raked into the system as a result of the use of GOLDBOD, the stability of the cedi, the currency of Ghana, all of which are profits. So, if there are transaction losses, and so what? In every transaction, we look at the loss versus the gain. We compare losses to

gains. We are ready to debate them, because we also have on record that when they started the implementation of the Reserve programme, there were equally significant transaction losses, in billions of Ghana cedis; we have the statistics. A loss without gain. In spite of the loss, we were still exchanging the Ghana cedi at over GH¢17.

With this small transaction loss of over US\$200 million, now we have the cedi coming down, averaging GH¢10 and GH¢11, and very stable. Inflation has come down. Our reserves have increased astronomically.

So, Mr Speaker, this is a debate that we are ready and prepared for. The Chairperson for the Committee on Economy and Development, today, is in a tie and a suit, waiting to participate in the debate. *[Hear! Hear!]* Hon Adongo has left all his work as a member of the board of the Central Bank, and is seated here, ready to respond to them *[Hear! Hear!]*. Everybody on this Side has come this morning, prepared to take this debate.

This is a very good Motion for the National Democratic Congress (NDC). It is a Motion that gives NDC the opportunity to market its achievement in the stability of the cedi. This is a Motion that indeed is favourable to the NDC. In fact, we should have brought this Motion. But it is good that they have brought it, and we are ready to take it. If there are procedural issues, let us clear them. At Conclave, I advised them on what to do. I am surprised because I thought they had done that, so we can have our way clear to take this Motion as

soon as possible. But they refused to do what I advised them to do. They come and stand here and say that they have lost confidence in my leadership. Am I the one who admits Motions? I make an application to the Speaker, and if he agrees, we take it. Even with Statements, I just got up and made an application to the Speaker to take a Statement. So, they know the issue. As for my friend, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, I believe he understands. I have a problem with why they do not understand. Or did he ask them to speak for him?

Mr Speaker, I think we can go and take Statements. As for the threat regarding Government Business, I do not even want us to go there. Government Business is business for all of us. And if they insist that we must bring all our numbers, we will bring all our numbers. But that should not be an issue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Minority Chief Whip got his facts right. The Majority in this House is stampeding the Business of the House. And, they are acting in bad faith. This House has been seized with this Motion for several weeks. They are never ready to be accountable. They are a walking contradiction.

The Majority Leader, on his feet, argued that the Motion has nothing to do with the GOLDBOD. For the avoidance of doubt, I will read the text of this Motion *in extenso*. Mr Speaker, this is what the Motion says,

“That this honourable House, pursuant to Article 103 of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 204, 212, 213, 262 and 263 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, establish an Ad hoc Committee to investigate the Gold-for-Reserves Scheme, including its design, implementation, governance, financial performance, environmental and public health implications, and any related matters.”

They are afraid of the Ad hoc Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, are you reading the Motion on the *Order Paper*?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, this Side of the House kept quiet and listened to the Majority Leader. What they do not know is that a Motion is always accompanied by an explanatory memo. They should know this. If they have not read the Standing Orders, I will stand here to educate them. So, they should listen.

Mr Speaker, the Motion, if we go to paragraph 3, I have the original text that has been approved by the Speaker. It says that,

“This Substantive Motion is setting out the composition, powers, terms of reference, reporting timelines, interim measures and implementation framework of the Ad hoc Committee”.

We have attached hereto the preamble. It is all required by the rules, and we complied. This is what the preamble says,

“Whereas Article 103 of the Constitution, empowers Parliament to appoint committees to investigate and enquire into the activities and administration of Ministries, Departments and Agencies; recalling Standing Orders 204, 212, 213, 262 and 263, which provide for the appointment of Ad hoc committees and confer powers to send for persons, papers and records; gravely concerned by the International Monetary Fund staff report for Ghana’s fifth review under the extended credit facility (December 2025), which document that the Bank of Ghana sustained foreign exchange losses of 204 million in the first nine months of 2025. Attributable to the Gold for Oil Reserve scheme.

1:08 p.m.

Further concern that the IMF report identifies significant downside risk to Ghana’s economic stabilisation programme arising from the scheme, including losses from failed trade, elevated off-taker fees and high operational costs...”

Mr Speaker, by the way, when the Minority raised these concerns, GOLDBOD and Bank of Ghana had an emergency joint meeting of their Boards, and slashed the fees to 9.55 per cent; this is an effective Minority. If at all, they were satisfied that the charges were okay

and there is a cost to implement an economic policy, why then did they meet? Why then did they convene that emergency meeting to reduce the charges from 15 per cent to 9.55 per cent? We are aware of all those facts.

Mr Speaker, it goes further to say:

“... alarmed by credible reports that substantial proportion of gold purchased under the scheme may originate from illegal mining operations, thereby implicating state institutions in the potential laundering of illicitly sourced minerals, deeply troubled by the environmental and public health crisis arising from illegal mining, including contamination, deforestation and projected potable water emergencies. Noting allegations of inadequate supply chain, due diligence, failure to implement mine level traceability consistent with Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) guidelines, and lack of transparency in the operations of GOLDBOD. Mindful of Parliament constitutional duty to exercise effective oversight of public institutions managing strategic national resources.

Now therefore, Mr Speaker—

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, the Majority Leader is up.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not allow him; he must have patience.

Mr Speaker, do not act in bad faith. He should let me finish. I am reading the full text.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, the Majority Leader is up. I give some recognition to you the Leaders.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker. I will still come back. He will not succeed in confusing this House. I have the full Motion here, and he is afraid that I am reading that the Ad hoc Committee Report to deal with GOLDBOD. Mr Speaker, it is here. We have the full document as admitted by the Speaker. They say they are ready. They should get ready so we debate it. As at December, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) reported that the losses have exceeded GH¢7 billion —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, I recognise the Majority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker. I would resume my seat for you to recognise him. I know he wants to re-argue; he has no point of order. But Mr Speaker, I will yield to him, but I will come back. He would not run away from this GOLDBOD Motion. The mass dismissal Motion is still waiting. They say they have 189 Members, and that they are a super majority. So, they should go ahead. We promise them that we will match them with substance, and they are afraid of substance. If their Chairman of Committee on Economy and Development is ready, he should debate. What are they afraid of? Why are they afraid of this Motion? They will say

it is procedural. What procedure are they talking about?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I recognise the Majority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I yield to him. What procedure are they talking about?

Mr Speaker, I am yielding to him, but what procedure was he talking about?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, for a man who says he does not fear, he is clearly afraid of the issues that I would raise. He is clearly afraid of the issues I will be raising.

Mr Speaker, let us get back to the Standing Orders. He spoke about a Motion and then a Memorandum. Could he specifically show us the Order that makes a Memorandum a part of the Motion? Mr Speaker, what is before us is a Motion in these terms:

“That this honourable House, pursuant to Article 103 of 1992 Constitution and Orders 204, 212, 213, 262, and 263 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, establish an Ad hoc Committee to investigate the Gold-for-Reserves Scheme...”

So actually, he is asking us to establish a committee to now conduct the investigation. So, he does not even have a basis for saying that wrong has been committed because he asked for an investigation. But he spoke as if wrong has been committed and someone is

running away from a wrong that has been committed. It goes further to say;

“...including its design, implementation, governance, financial performance, environmental and public implications, and any related matters”.

Mr Speaker, this is the Motion before us. So, when he gets up to read a tall order in a Memorandum, it is not part of the Motion; that is not what has been advertised. If he has written a Memorandum and has added the name of GOLDBOD on the face of this *Order Paper*, no Member sees the name of GOLDBOD. So, GOLDBOD is not an issue here—[*Interruption*]. No, let us be fair. He cannot just stand there and say anything about an institution of State and make wild allegations relating to that institution. I am saying that he is out of order because what he has is a Motion, and it has not been considered yet. So, he should exercise patience. He has raised his issues, and we have responded to the issues.

Mr Speaker, he seems to want to debate the Motion, but clearly, there is nothing that he can say that has not been said already about this Motion. So, I would urge him to let us continue with the Business of the day. As for this Motion, I have shown him how to resolve the issue of the Motion. I cannot say everything before the cameras, but I have told him that we are ready. He should go to Order 102. That Order deals with the Notice of Motions. He should go and read it. He can also read Order 103, but he can start from Order 100. When he reads all those Orders, he

would not see anything about a Memorandum. His Motion is his Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the rules of the House must be read as a whole. A Motion is a Motion, and he, the Majority Leader, as a practitioner of the law, must know that one does not appear before an adjudicating body with a lame Motion. A Motion must always be accompanied with the law and facts.

Mr Speaker, if we read Order 111(b), it says:

“... the notice shall be accompanied with an explanatory note stating the reasons for proposing the Motion;”

That is in the rules. We can never get it wrong. The Minority are few in number, but we do our research. We are few.

Mr Speaker, whether Half- Hour Motion, or Substantive Motion, or whatever, a Motion must be a—Mr Speaker, the rules must be applied *mutatis mutandis*.

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader—[*Interruption*]. No, he has had his bite. Can he take a rest? As a lawyer, patience is part of his virtues. He should sit down. He cannot come twice on a point of order. He should let me finish—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well Minority Leader, Order 111(b) is talking about Half-Hour Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not join this debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am not joining the debate.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me finish. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, he should sit down; I will listen to him. So, now who is afraid?

1:18 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, Standing Order 111(b) deals with Half-Hour Motions.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I referred to it. I use the language—Mr Speaker, you are a lawyer, and I am a lawyer. The Latin expression, *mutatis mutandis* was invoked by me to support my argument. Mr Speaker, I must be heard by the Majority Leader.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us just admit that the condition for admissibility of Half-Hour Motions is different from a Motion. Let us straighten up the record, then you can continue.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I am arguing, Mr Speaker, with respect, I am arguing that the rule must be looked at *mutatis mutandis*. That is my argument, and it is allowed by law. That is a law.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader there is no doctrine of infallibility—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, can I finish!

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We listen to you, but when the Speaker is speaking, you also have the courtesy to listen to the Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you should caution him too. He is finding fault on this Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You should have the courtesy to listen to the Speaker. This is a House of Records, and we all know that admissibility of a Motion is different from the condition of admissibility of a Half-Hour Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I am not wrong!

An Hon Member: Mr Speaker is talking, listen.

[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I believe your Motion on record is not a Half-Hour Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Majority Leader's argument— *[Interruption]*

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we are taking Statements.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The Majority Leader's argument is that the Motion should not— *[Interruption]*

Mr Ayariga: I am saying we will not allow this. We are taking Statements.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: When the Speaker has allowed—so when the Speaker has allowed—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker has granted me the right of audience. The Speaker has granted me the right of audience. *[Interruption]* Yes, but the Speaker has granted me the right of audience. *[Interruption]* Majority Leader, are you now the Speaker? *[Interruption]* Yes, but the Speaker has granted me the right of audience. I have the right of audience.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: May I ask my two Leaders to resume their seats? May I ask my two Leaders to resume their seats? May I humbly ask my two Leaders to resume their seats?

Leaders, please, kindly resume your seats.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have the right of audience now—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Leaders, kindly resume your seats.

[Uproar]

Hon Minority Leader, also resume your seat.

Hon Minority Leader, you should also resume your seat! *[Interruption]*

I did not ask you to put your microphone off; I said resume your seats. Leaders, why? We are not arguing the Motion.

Minority Chief Whip just drew attention to this matter, that those Motions would have to be taken, and that ends it. There cannot be any further argument generating to what we are seeing. Why?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you on a point of order against the Speaker?

Hon Habib, you know when the Speaker is speaking or whoever is presiding is speaking, and you are on your feet, it simply means you are on a point of order against the Speaker, and it is not done.

The Frontbench would have to help us to maintain order in the House. So why are all these happening? It is not the best.

Yes, what do you have to say?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. It is not in relation to this matter. Mr Speaker, just an observation, and I would want to draw your attention to Article 102 of the Constitution.

Mr Speaker, Article 102 of the Constitution, with your permission, I read:

“A quorum of Parliament, apart from the person presiding, shall be one-third of all the members of Parliament.”

Mr Speaker, I have been fortified by Standing Order 64, and it also states that:

“(1) A quorum of Parliament apart from the person presiding, is one-third of all the Members of Parliament.”

Mr Speaker, I have taken notice of Standing Order 64(2), where Standing Order 64(2) states that:

“(2) Where the person presiding is a Deputy Speaker or a Member, that person shall be counted as part of the quorum.”

Mr Speaker, I have counted, and our Colleagues in the Majority are 47 in number, and we are 23 in number. Mr Speaker, we did not constitute the quorum to commence Business. Mr Speaker, I invite you to apply the rules in this matter, that we do not have quorum to continue with Business.

I so submit, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Education.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am also rising on a completely different subject, but a matter which must be of interest to the Parliament of Ghana and this House. Mr Speaker, I drew your attention, but I was trying to clear with Leadership. The Supreme Court of Ghana has given a ruling on matters relating to asset declaration rules for public officers, including Members of Parliament. In that ruling, the Supreme Court says no grace period. Mr Speaker, when Parliament passed Public Office Holders (Declaration of Asset and

Disqualification) Act, 1998 (Act 550), it provided for a certain period for which assets are to be declared by public office holders.

Mr Speaker, Mr Mensah Thompson of the Alliance for Social Equity and Public Accountability (ASEPA), is the one who went to question and ask for the exclusive jurisdiction of the Supreme Court in interpreting Article 286 of the 1992 Constitution and compared it against Section 4 of the Public Office Holders (Declaration of Asset and Disqualification) Act, 1998 (Act 550). Mr Speaker, that ruling must guide this House. Is that to suggest that the Parliament of Ghana is not sovereign and therefore in the exercise of our mandate in Article 93 of the 1992 Constitution, this Parliament is subject to the Constitution and subject to the judicial powers of the State. By striking out this six-month period, Mr Speaker—Why I raise this is because when Parliament is passing legislation, we are guided. For instance, if it says one must declare assets before assumption of office, that is a ruling of the Supreme Court.

Mr Speaker, I know that in constitutional jurisprudence, the Supreme Court must be responding to eliminating absurdity in legislation. But will this not yield another absurdity? For instance, if one is nominated as a Minister or a Chief Executive, at what point is one to declare assets when it says one must declare the assets before?

Mr Speaker, I am just bringing this because you are a good lawyer. What is the Parliament of Ghana required to do? Because we are subject to the 1992

Constitution. But I find this ruling of interest to what we do here. Firstly, if it is to guide us in future in respect of legislation that this House will look at. I know that there may be a request for a comprehensive review of the entire asset declaration regime to serve our country better in order to make it more transparent and more accountable. I am all with the Supreme Court if they want to strengthen transparency and accountability, but the absence of a grace period, and not knowing when a public officer assumes office, even a Chief Executive, I thought that I should bring it to the attention of the House. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much and Hon Minister for Education, you know we make the law, but we do not interpret the law. The law is always interpreted by the courts. That is why we say the law lies in the bosom of the judge. That is the interpretation given by the Supreme Court regarding the asset declaration. So, until that decision is reversed, that is the law. We will have to go by it, unfortunately.

Now, back to the issue raised by Hon Habib. I would invoke Standing Order 64—

Yes?

1:28 p.m.

Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten: Mr Speaker, I am grateful for this opportunity. I rise to share a concern on the issue of quorum that was raised. Mr Speaker, we know you have experience in this House and your knowledge of our Standing Orders is impeccable. We saw

a number of Minority Members here when the Leader raised the issue of quorum. Then, whilst they are raising quorum, without being mindful of satisfying the one-third provision of Article 102 of the Constitution and our Standing Orders, they start filing out to create the situation for quorum not being formed. Mr Speaker, I call on you to exercise discretion in this matter.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, just a while ago, the First Deputy Minority Whip raised an issue pertaining to quorum, that the House is inquorate. I beg to differ. At the time he was on his feet, they were 35, but he under-declared that they were 27. At the time he was on his feet, we were 75. *[Laughter]* Oh, they can do the counting. So, if we add 35 to 75, the House is not inquorate, within the meaning—*[Interruption]*—He provided figures, I am also providing figures. So, this penchant for frustrating Business of the House, which they decried just a while ago—

Mr Speaker, the House is properly constituted. We have the quorate to continue with Business. As earlier pleaded by the Leader, let us move to the item numbered 7 and take Statements. If indeed the Chair is minded, Mr Speaker, the procedure provided under Order 64 can be triggered. But I am saying that the basis upon which he made that prayer is unfounded because the House was properly quorate.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip needs to advert to Order 64(4) (c). When a matter of quorum is raised on the floor of Parliament, Order 64(4) gives directives

on what the person presiding should do. It does not lie in the hands of the Majority Chief Whip to, at that point, tell the First Deputy Speaker who is very experienced what to do. Standing Order 64(4) says that: “The person presiding shall...”. The Hon Majority Chief Whip is a lawyer and knows that when “shall” is used, it becomes mandatory, and that the person presiding must comply. That is exactly what he was moving to do before the Minority Chief Whip decided to buy time to whip his Members in. In any case, they are 189, and they need 92 or 93 to commence Business. So why is he saying that we are 23? If they are 75—*[Uproar]*. They need 92 to continue.

Mr Speaker, Order 64(4) (c) says that “The person presiding shall direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to conduct a head count of members present”. So, it is not to him to do a head count. The counting he did was a waste of time, because he does not have any authority to do that counting. It is the Speaker who can direct the procedure to be followed. So, Mr Speaker, I still say that we do not have that quorum, and for that matter, do the needful. If at the end of the day, it is established, which I am very convinced, that even at that moment, we do not have the quorum and are not up to 92 to commence a Business. I invite you to apply the rules.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when it is our turn, we will keep quiet.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, your Second Deputy Whip was on his feet and I recognised him, but he has decided not to use the opportunity. Now the Majority Leader is on his feet, so why will I not recognise the Majority Leader? I rule if nobody is up to speak. The Majority Leader is up, so what do I do? Hon Members, what do I do?

Yes, Majority Leader, let me hear you.

Mr Ayariga: Yes, Mr Speaker. I do not think there is a problem with going through the processes outlined in our Standing Orders. What I recall is that the bell developed a fault and was not ringing in the offices. So, I just want a

confirmation that the bell rings in the offices. That is all that I am cautioning, that we ensure that the bell rings in the offices. Because the rules say that the Speaker will direct for the bell to be rang for a certain number of minutes. But I just want to be sure that when the bell is rung, it will ring in the offices of the Members of Parliament (MPs).

It is the verification that I think the Speaker should embark upon. So, when the Speaker directs that the bell be rung, he has to ask the Clerks-at-the-Table to verify that the ringing is also taking place in the offices so that MPs can be prompted to come back into the Chamber. Even as the Minority deplete their numbers by deliberately walking out, we want to make sure that those who are not in the Chamber actually have noticed that we need them in the Chamber for us to proceed with Government Business.

So, Mr Speaker, while this is going on, can we start with the Statement by the Minister for Roads and Highways? Mr Speaker, they cannot say that we cannot. They can ring the bell, but directing that the bell should be rung does not mean that proceedings should be brought to a halt. No, proceedings should not be brought to a halt. Proceedings will continue even as the bell is being rung for the time period that the bell is rung. If at the end of that time period the Speaker decides to conduct the headcount, then we can look at the figures and see if there is—Yes, so it is clear that “The person presiding shall continue the business of the House for a period of ten minutes”.

After the Speaker has decided and the bell is being rung, we have 10 minutes to proceed with Government Business as the MPs troop into the Chamber. So, Mr Speaker, that is guidance that I am seeking from you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the rule invoked is very clear. Actually, we do not base the decision on the Member’s count when attention is drawn to the absence of a quorum. I would direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to cause the bell to be rang for 10 minutes and by Standing Order 64(4) (b), Business of the House shall continue.

1:38 p.m.

I will therefore call on the Minister for Roads and Highways to present his Statement. Clerks-at-the-Table, you may proceed to ring the bell and make sure you ring the bell physically at the Committee rooms as well as the offices.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, you raised the issue, and I have given my directives. Unless you are saying I am not operating within the rules.

STATEMENT

Update on the Implementation of the Big Push Infrastructure Project

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to present to you an update

on President Mahama's flagship infrastructure development project, the Big Push.

Mr Speaker, you may recall that President Mahama dedicated the first two years of the Big Push Programme to address the unprecedented, deplorable state of our road network. Through the Big Push Infrastructure Programme launched in 2025, the Government is investing heavily in repairing critical roads, upgrading key economic corridors, creating jobs, and reducing the cost of doing business across all 16 regions. The Programme places strong emphasis on Ghanaian contractors and workers, helping to strengthen local technical expertise in the construction sector.

Mr Speaker, the Big Push Programme has received strong support from Parliament so far. This House has approved nearly GH¢50 billion for these multi-year road and bridge projects. We appreciate the support from Leadership and Members of this House. As I speak, over 2000 km of roads in all 16 regions of our country are under extensive transformation. Mr Speaker, in times past, we have all been concerned by the state of our roads, mindful of the amount of money invested. In the spirit of probity, accountability, and transparency, we encourage the public to remain engaged in monitoring the project in their localities, and we always appreciate their constructive feedback.

Mr Speaker, recently, an online platform requested details about ongoing road projects, and same was willingly and timeously provided. There was no

attempt to conceal any information. Mr Speaker, no ministry is subjected to as much consistent scrutiny as the Ministry of Roads and Highways. On average, about 10 Questions are filed weekly, covering wide-ranging issues from contract awards to project costs and timeliness. The Ministry also regularly gets invitations from Committees of Parliament to respond to developments within the sector.

Mr Speaker, I welcome the scrutiny. It strengthens accountability and ensures that we remain aligned with the expectations of the Ghanaian people. I wish to assure the House that I take the responsibility entrusted to me with utmost seriousness. I remain fully committed to delivering on our mandate with integrity, transparency, and efficiency. Mr Speaker, prior to the 2024 election, it was clear that the majority of Ghanaians were not happy with the deplorable and dangerous nature of roads across the country. They made it a condition that when given the mandate, the Government of President Mahama should take urgent and immediate steps to improve the country's road network. This has been justifiably followed by consistent Questions of timeliness from Members of this House concerning when the roads in their constituencies would be improved.

Mr Speaker, this is a House of record. Let me state unequivocally that all contracts awarded under the Programme were done in strict adherence to the Public Procurement Act, 2003 (Act 663) and its accompanying regulations. Mr Speaker, all contractual information is

publicly available and on the Ministry's website. The original Big Push project identified 12 major economic corridors across the country, which were christened the 12 Disciples. These projects were later broken into 54 lots to speed up implementation and foster competition. Mr Speaker, additionally, 23 road projects valued at GH¢14.88 billion, which were awarded by the previous administration and abandoned by contractors due to lack of dedicated funding, were absorbed as part of the Big Push. These projects were novated to be 'Big Push' under the new funding.

Mr Speaker, these are some of the projects: the design and construction of Suame Interchange and Ancillary works (Phase I), design and construction of Suame Interchange Local Roads (Phase II), Takoradi-Agona Rehabilitation and Dualisation, including two dual carriage-way Bridges, rehabilitation of Tepa-Mabangoso Road, reconstruction of Jinijini-Sampa Road, rehabilitation and upgrading of Kasoa-Winneba Road, rehabilitation of Kasoa-Winneba (Lots 1-3), rehabilitation of Ofankor-Nsawam Road, design, build, and dualisation of Adenta-Dodowa, upgrade of Nkwanta-Oti Damanko Road (Km 0.0–50.3), upgrade of Tumu-Sisili-Navrongo Road, upgrade of Tumu-Chuchuliga-Navrongo Road, partial reconstruction of Navrongo-Chuchuliga-Tumu Road, upgrade of Tumu-Han-Lawra Road (Km 45–70), all the way to the upgrade of Tumu-Han-Lawra Road, construction of National Route 8 (Wa-Han-Lawra Road), rehabilitation of Hohoe-Jasikan, and then construction of Have-Hohoe Road.

Mr Speaker, globally, sole sourcing is acceptable in situations where there is a need to extend the implementation of works which were previously competitively procured to speed up completion. The 23 projects I talked about that we novated, none of them were competitively procured. They were all sole sourced contracts which were novated at a cost of GH¢14.8 billion. Mr Speaker, given the scale, agency, and national importance of these projects, a mix of procurement methods was employed in accordance with the law. It is important to note that only 44 per cent of all the major contracts included in the Big Push Programme were awarded by the Ministry under sole sourcing. So, it is not what has been published by a certain online portal. We have also awarded over 400 different contracts through open competitive bidding, which is unprecedented. The record shows that from 2017 to 2024, almost all projects that the Ministry carried out were sole-sourced. It will therefore be mischievous for any right-thinking member of society to conclude that the Ministry of Roads and Highways only procures works through sole sourcing.

Mr Speaker, I have already mentioned the deplorable state of the road network across the country which we inherited from our Colleagues. This had brought untold hardship to the motoring public and contributed massively to the food inflation which led to public agitation and the survival of the state. Mr Speaker, something needed to be done and done urgently. Mr Speaker, with dedicated funding already secured under the Big Push programme, it was both prudent and necessary to proceed

swiftly to ensure value for money and avoid cost overruns associated with long procurement and implementation time-lines. Mr Speaker, most of the projects would not have started to date if we had not adopted a faster route.

1:48 p.m.

The following projects, for example, would not have been continued or started: the Kasoa-Winneba Road and Kasoa interchange, which is in the Constituency of my good Friend, the Hon Minority Leader; the dualisation of Winneba-Cape Coast Road; the Suame Interchange project which was stalled but now has gotten a new life; the Kumasi Outer Ring Road; and the Ofankor-Nsawam road are part of this.

Mr Speaker, we put in place the following mechanisms to ensure value for money in terms of cost, quality and longevity. Contrary to the previous practice, under the Big Push Programme, agencies did their own survey design and costing, saving billions. Mr Speaker, I say this because in the past, this project would have been designed and build. But by asking the agencies to actually do our own design costing, we have saved at least 5 per cent of the cost of the project. So, we have started saving money on this project, making sure that the country gets the best in terms of the value for money. Contractors were then invited to submit proposals which were then subjected to independent value for money assessment. We have instituted a stricter monitoring and cost control mechanism to ensure we only pay for works done. We have now established a system where no contractor

would walk away with a cedi without working for it. We have also reached an understanding with the Ghana Institution of Surveyors (GhIS) to develop the local capacity of members to be licensed as independent value for money auditors.

Mr Speaker, it is important to point out the deliberate falsehood that rely on simplified metrics such as cost per kilometre without considering the scope of works. For the avoidance of doubt, under the reset leadership of President Mahama, road projects have not been unjustifiably suspended or terminated. The huge unpaid debt of over GH¢40 billion has also received attention of the Government. Over GH¢11 billion has been paid so far to contracts all awarded or inherited from our Brothers from the other Side. The Government has not abandoned any ongoing project. Indeed, the Accra-Kumasi Bypass project has not been abandoned. We have completed one of the lots and have taken it over. The rest of the lots have been programmed to be budgeted for in the 2027 Budget if Parliament approves. However, the cost to complete, including the outstanding debt of the Kumasi Bypasses, is estimated at GH¢6 billion as at today.

Mr Speaker, let me state emphatically that when it comes to the Big Push Programme, Parliament exercised continuous oversight. Questions are answered regularly on the floor of the House. Independent professional bodies validated the project cost. Procurement processes complied with established legal framework. There is no abuse of the sole sourcing programme. Unlike

previously, it is the exception and not the norm. Indeed, no procurement law or any other law has been breached, and definitely there is no scandal. The implementation of the Big Push programme—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, I say this as a matter of fact. I am not responding to anybody except those who are falsifying information on social media. The NDC did not award over GH¢70 billion worth of work under the Big Push. Indeed, we said GH¢54 billion of that was for new works, and then the 23 projects were projects that we inherited costing another GH¢14.8 billion. Indeed, Mr Speaker, there is spurious information online that 76 per cent of the projects is sole sourced also false.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, just go ahead with your Statement.

Mr Agbodza: Only about 44 per cent of those projects were procured through sole sourcing. I state on record, Mr Speaker, we are making progress as a House and as a country to make sure that much of our procurement is done competitively. That is why I am saying that those who claim to have done this so-called analysis based on data we submitted to them freely did not help the country because if they did due diligence, they would have known that those percentages they put outside were pure fabrications and false.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, the Government of President Mahama has taken steps to improve the procurement process. As a matter of fact, as I said, I am not having

a go at our Colleagues on the other Side. I say that today as Minister, almost the GH¢110 billion worth of projects we inherited were all procured through sole sourcing. I do not blame them, Mr Speaker. I sat on that Side of the House not too long ago when the people of Suame demonstrated against the respected former Leader, Hon Kyei-Mensah-Bonsu, I supported the fact that we should procure the Suame Interchange project through sole sourcing because it was urgent and we needed to do it. When the Accra-Tema Motorway project was awarded to Mota-Engil, a foreign company, and they could not raise the financing, I was one of the first people to say let us terminate the work and get a Ghanaian contractor to do it. In this House, we also agreed that that project should also be awarded on sole sourcing to the contractor, Maripoma Enterprise Limited.

I say this simply because the impression is that when we were in opposition, we said nothing about sole sourcing was good, and now that we are in government, we are doing the opposite. Mr Speaker, what I presented to you today shows that everything has to be done in context. What I will say here, contractors on all Big Push projects are on site and works are ongoing, and by the end of 2027, Mr Speaker, we would see a lot of completed road projects that will enhance our economy, make our roads safer. This is why I tell Colleagues, let us work together to make sure that we protect the Big Push. Let us not fall for any agenda of anybody outside of this House. This is the House of Parliament. The debate, the formulation of policy of

anything that has to do with governance stands here, and not anybody outside.

I want to take the opportunity to thank the entire country for the support they have given to the Big Push programme. President Mahama is not in the business of skewing anything to disadvantage the people of Ghana. Contractors on Big Push projects are on site, and works are ongoing, and shall be completed on schedule and on budget.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

I have in my hands a document that I will table, Mr Speaker, that contain advertisements of all the projects we advertised. Over 400 of them were competitively awarded. So those who are basing on 70 projects to strike out at the difference, this is the information I have for them. Majority of the projects we are embarking on were actually procured through competitive bidding. I also mentioned that all that we are doing with regard to the Big Push project are already on our website, so we are not concealing any information. In terms of the description of the project, the scope of work, the name of the contractor, the day the contract starts and when it is expected to be completed are there. So, nobody has gotten a scoop, and indeed, Mr Speaker, there is no scandal about the Big Push.

2:32 p.m.

The Big Push Programme was approved by this House and we shall make sure that it delivers to the people of our country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before coming to comments, for my sake, let us take few minutes' suspension.

1:59 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

2:32 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the House is called to order. Yes, Hon Kennedy Nyarko?

Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei (NPP — Akim Swedru): Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity to make a few comments on the Statement presented by the Minister for Roads and Highways. As I was sitting here, I was carefully monitoring the demeanour and the facial expression of the Minister. I am sure he has regretted some of the comments he made in the past with regard to the issue that he has presented to the House regarding sole sourcing. But it is important for this House to also note that inasmuch as we are not against any issue of sole sourcing, it does not have to be abused by anybody in office. Section 40(1) of the Public Procurement Act, 2003 (Act 663), has prescribed how these things can be done, but it must not be butchered or abused. No government should take advantage of this very section and award contracts that are going to be paid with the taxpayers' money.

Mr Speaker, I am not against any situation like that. For instance, if a contractor is working on the Asamankese road for instance and he has mobilised his site and has his site camp and the Ministry wants to award another contract on the Akroso to Oda road, it is only reasonable for an addendum be given for that contractor to be awarded the contract through sole sourcing because he is already on that stretch and has his camp already set up. This will even save the nation because if a new contractor moves to the site, the State will need to pay for the camp setting among others. In this case, one can be justified in giving that contractor the addendum or the additional work.

Mr Speaker, when we have a contract valued at GH¢1 billion for instance, and we give it through sole sourcing, it creates some kind of doubt or impression in the minds of the people. I am not saying that someone has done any wrongdoing anywhere. But I am saying that it is time for we the politicians to respect the very law that we have passed. We do not need to overdo or butcher or abuse the very section of the Procurement Act that has given us the leeway to do that. The Minister made mention of the previous Government awarding a lot of contracts that did not go through any competitive tendering. Could the Minister furnish this House those contracts which were awarded, that did not go through that competitive tendering? He should be able to do so because he has been able to table those contracts he has awarded. So, he should be in the same position to also table those contracts, so Ghanaians will know the

contracts awarded by the previous administration without taking them through competitive tendering.

I am not here to justify any action as such by the previous Government or this Government, but what I am saying is that they complained and accused the previous Government some time ago and even impugned corrupt practices against those people. Today, can I ask the Minister who the beneficiaries are in these single-sourced contracts they have awarded to those contractors to pursue? Is it President Mahama who is going to benefit?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Hajia Laadi?

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by the Minister. Mr Speaker, the issue of roads is an issue that every Ghanaian is interested in and wishes that it goes well. I sat quietly and I listened to the Minister and as a person who has been on the Committee on Roads and Transportation, I am not in doubt of what I am saying neither am I in doubt of what the Minister said. I just listened to my former Chairperson of the Committee on Roads and Transportation and interestingly, he made a statement that surprised me about the Akroso road where he supposes that the Minister could have given it to the contractor that was on site and it sounds like a dream to me, because I have never seen them do that. I never saw the New Patriotic Party (NPP), for that matter, do that. All I saw was that they came and rather stopped

road projects. The road from Bolgatanga – Bawku – Pulmakom, my own constituency, was stopped barely two weeks after they came into power. We were not asking for them to continue to any other place, but for the work to be continued. It never happened for the eight years. So, listening to them, it sounds like a dream to me.

Mr Speaker, he also mentioned that the Minister should have mentioned some of the roads that were given through sole sourcing, but he did not do it. And I would mention but a few to you for your consumption and maybe if he needs more, he could get them later from the Minister for Roads and Highways. Mr Speaker, the roads are rehabilitation of Odenteng – Boahen area roads, 3.6 km. When one checks, one would find that it was not advertised. There was no competitive tendering. Bantama area and its environs, 10.50 km, Phase 2: there was no competitive tendering. Bantama and its environs, Phase 1: no competitive tendering. Pothole patching, sectional repairs and resealing of arterial roads in Oforikrom: no competitive tendering. And yet, this is what a former Chairperson is talking about.

2:40 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is unfortunate that the Minister for Roads and Highways in his presentation mentioned how much they left in debt. They left in debt with some roads costing not less than GH¢14.88 billion. When our Government came into office, we never stopped those projects; the projects have been listed on the page numbered 4 of his Statement.

I think we should appreciate the fact that this Government never abandoned those projects because, we need the roads. We are not denying the fact that they are talking about the awarding of contracts through sole sourcing of contracts. But they should know that they have done it, and we have all the information with us.

Mr Speaker, I want to encourage the Minister to continue with his good works and also to let them know that out of the 2,000-kilometre roads that are being done, the Upper East, especially, Pusiga is benefiting. We have Sanam Ghana Limited working from Yariga Number 2 to Pusiga Town and we also have Pezzo Construction, working from Wuyana Town to Yariga Number 2 and we have others for now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, it has been more than an hour since the bell was first rung. The bell was first rung at 1:41 p.m. They have gone into Conclave, so when you look at the Backbench—We have still been waiting for them to give direction on Order 64(3) and (4c) which is to:

“direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to conduct a headcount of members present;”

Mr Speaker, respectfully, that is our call on this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, are we continuing on the comments?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we would continue with the comments.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I made a call and I was thinking you would give me an indication—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I know what exactly I am doing, so just resume your seat.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, there is a need for you to tell me so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: They are counting.

Mr Shaib: Very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor? You have the floor for five minutes.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Statement made by the Minister for Roads and Highways and the comments relating to the Statement should go beyond the New Patriotic Party (NPP) and the National Democratic Congress (NDC) contestations; it should go beyond Pusiga as well.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect to my big Sister, this is really not a matter of point scoring. It is the Fourth Estate that put out an exposé relating to

the number of sole-sourced contracts under the Ministry of Roads and Highways. The Minister has found it prudent to make a Statement more or less in response to the Report put out by the Fourth Estate.

Mr Speaker, before I say anything further, may I refer the House to the page numbered 6 of the Minister's own Statement, specifically, the paragraph numbered 24. In that paragraph, the Minister concedes that 44 per cent of all the major contracts, including, in this case to quote him, "The Big Push Contracts" awarded by his Ministry under President Mahama, were procured through sole-sourcing.

Mr Speaker, I am referring to the almost 50 per cent of the contracts awarded under the Ministry of Roads and Highways which were done through sole-sourcing. This is by the Hon Minister's own say-so. This is a Statement he has given to Parliament. In other words, the Hon Minister confirms and/or corroborates the report put out by the Fourth Estate, a civil society investigative journalistic Institute.

Mr Speaker, that revelation was not made by the Minority; it was not made by the NPP. It was made by the Fourth Estate. The Minister has come to Parliament on the page numbered 6, the paragraph numbered 24 and the Hon Minister has corroborated it.

Mr Speaker, the question I want to ask is that even before that – just last week, we had the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026 before this House and

we did debate it. I had the occasion on that day to indicate that, there is a need for us as a country to interrogate the procurement mechanism of sole-sourcing and restrictive tender. We took some considerable time to distinguish between public competitive tender, restrictive tender, and sole-sourcing.

Mr Speaker, let us face it, when people get agitated and worried about sole-sourcing, it is normally because, civil societies, stakeholders and actors in the body politic seems to think that sole-sourcing lends itself to opaque transactions and by that, I do not necessarily refer to this instant case. But when people raise issues on why one awards such a contract through sole-sourcing, the concern globally is normally because, pundits feel that when it is sole-sourced, the room for opaque transaction and underhand dealings is easier.

The Minister has come before us and told us that, he has done half of his contracts through sole-sourcing; he has admitted it. The Fourth Estate has come up with all kinds of suggestions, allegations and so on and so forth—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Bedzrah, you have the floor.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me commend the Minister for Roads and Highways for bringing this Statement to the fore, in response to some media speculations and media reportage.

Mr Speaker, if you would permit me, Section 40 of the Public Procurement Act, 2003 (Act 663) which was passed in this House, says that:

“A procurement entity may engage in a single-source procurement under section 1, with the approval of the board in the following exceptional circumstances.”

Mr Speaker, this clearly tells you that, indeed, the Law that we passed in this House, has given support to sole-sourcing. Under which circumstances? The circumstances have been enumerated in the Procurement Act.

Mr Speaker, those of us who are in the built-environment industry, have argued in the past, including my Colleague, that sole-sourcing by the previous administration, which was almost 100 per cent, was too much, to the extent that I have to question my own institution, the Ghana Institution of Surveyors, for allowing the institution to be used for some sole sourcing activities.

2:52 p.m.

That was 100 per cent sole sourcing and we would ask ourselves that where are we going in this country? The cardinal issue under sole sourcing is the fact that there should be value-for-money auditing or monitoring. The Minister has made it clear that this Big Push contract, which we all know has issues with the media, has value-for-money auditing contract consultant attached to the contract.

Mr Speaker, Paragraph 22 of the Minister's Statement said,

"Mr Speaker, it is globally acceptable to use sole sourcing even in situations where there is a need to extend the implementation of works which were previously competitively procured to speed up completion. Even the above 23 projects were previously procured competitively."

Mr Speaker, clearly, in the previous administration, projects were given out on sole-sourced basis. So, if today, 44 per cent of contracts are given out on sole sourcing and not 100 per cent, this is in the right direction because we are reducing. If it had been 100 per cent, then those of us who were arguing against sole sourcing at that time would also come after the Minister. But I can tell you that reducing it from 100 per cent to 44 per cent is far better than 100 per cent. Not only that. We also have value-for-money auditors attached to the contract. So if anybody has an issue, all they have to do is to find out whether there is value for money or there is some under dealing in the award of contracts.

Mr Speaker, I am aware that the Kasoa-Winneba Road was sole-sourced until this Government came to regularise it and moved on with the contract. We could have abrogated it because it was under sole sourcing. We all know that the Winneba Interchange was sole-sourced. The dualisation of the Winneba Road was sole-sourced. Suame Interchange was sole-sourced. We all know in this House that they were sole sourced. The

Kumasi outer lane was also sole-sourced. But the current Administration and the current Minister decided that even though it was sole-sourced, they would look at it and allow it to go so that the work continue.

Mr Speaker, this clearly shows that we have moved from 100 per cent to 44 per cent and I am sure by the time we finish with the Value-for-Money law, we would come to 0 per cent when it comes to sole sourcing.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib has again drawn my attention to the issue of quorum.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I know we have had some backstage discussions. There are three Committees sitting as we speak. In fact, it is advertised on our *Order Paper* that the Committee on Transport, the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, and the Committee on Assurances are sitting. In that regard, I think that the appropriate thing for us to do is to take an adjournment so that these Committees can finish their work and then tomorrow we can proceed on all fours. Given that we have not done up to five hours, I move that his House be adjourned to tomorrow at 10 o'clock in the forenoon.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before taking any secondment, let me acknowledge the presence of students from Presbyterian Senior High School, Larteh Akuapem led by

Frank Adu Asare, Assistant Headmaster. They are from Akuapem North and they are 67 in number.

[Students of Presbyterian Senior High School, Larteh Akuapem were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have students from Presbyterian Senior High School, Mampong, led by Gifty Amoatey, Assistant Headmistress in charge of administration. They are from Akuapem North and they are number 65 in number. Hon Members, on your behalf I welcome them to Parliament and urge them to have a fruitful visit.

[Students of Presbyterian Senior High School, Mampong were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader, a moment ago, knowing that after several hours he is still not being able to secure a minimum to conduct Business, is now saying that there are three Committees having meetings so there should be an adjournment. This sends one signal; the signal that there must always be consensus.

Mr Dafeamekpor — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Chief Whip, are you on a point of order?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the point of order?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader, when he was on his feet—Yes, I am on my feet on point of order on grounds that he is misinforming the House. The Minority Leader's business is to second the Motion pending before the House. But, in doing so, he is misinforming the House that my Side has not commandeered the numbers. This is the attendance for the day. I have 122 of my Side — *[Hear! Hear!]* —I have not even added their Side which was in excess of 35.

Mr Speaker, the Motion by the Majority Leader to adjourn the House was well founded and he gave reasons. Three major Committees are presently in session, so if the Minority Leader is not minded to second the Motion, I will do so then perhaps you can hear him.

Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion presently before the House. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, I will give you the floor but before then let me make this announcement on World Oral Health Day observation.

Hon Members of Parliament are respectfully invited to the commemoration of the 2026 World Oral Health Day under the theme “A Happy Mouth is a Happy Life”. The launch will take place on Wednesday 25th March, 2026 at 9 a.m. at the Justice D. F. Annan Auditorium. Screening and consultation will begin after the launch at the Parliament Medical Centre, the Dental Unit, until 4 p.m. and continue each day

from 9 a.m. to 4 p.m. until Friday 27th March, 2026. Hon Members are encouraged to participate in this important health programme. Thank you for the audience.

Yes, Minority Leader, the Motion has been moved and seconded, it is now for the consideration of the House.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I was on my feet with some preliminary issues in respect of the Motion by the Majority Leader and the Majority Chief Whip came in on a point of order, he argued his point of order and promised to allow me to continue my submissions and all I hear now is that the Motion has been seconded.

Mr Speaker, we are dealing with public records but it is obvious that the Majority Side is in deep crisis this afternoon. Before I discharge my duty of formally seconding this Motion, let me put this across and it goes to my Colleagues in Government — I am surprised that today Fourth Estate has come out with findings and it has been disputed. I have been cautioning that let us all be measured.

Mr Speaker, the issue of Strategic Mobilisation Ghana Limited (SML) came from the Fourth Estate. The very issue that all of them on that Side of the House are crucifying Ken Ofori Atta and have not given him the opportunity to be heard, today, we are being told that sole sourcing is 44 per cent and people are talking percentages.

3:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we are political leaders, and it is important for us to sit around national issues. It is important that on core national issues, we, political leaders, find space to build consensus.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, can I not speak?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You can speak, but speak to the issue on the Floor. Once the House has been moved for adjournment—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we, in Leadership, are allowed some space to act in the public interest. That is why I said before I formally—Mr Speaker, if you think that it is wrong for me to go ahead, I will just resume my seat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hear me out. If you want this to happen, Hon Jerry Shaib would not have been pressing on the issue of quorum. I have the numbers here to call and do the needful.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let the record bear us out that the Majority is not in crisis. The Majority Leadership is not in crisis.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 3:05 p.m. till Wednesday, 25th March, 2026 at 10:00 a.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 27th March, 2026.